

3.4 Population density

To identify districts where the population is highly concentrated, it is necessary to examine the distribution of the population in relation to land area. In other words, the number of persons living per square kilometer of land area namely, population density should be analyzed. The population densities calculated by district for the census years 1981, 2001, 2012, and 2024 are presented in Table 3.4.

Table 3.4 : Population Density by District, 1981, 2001, 2012 and 2024

District	Population Density (Persons per Square Kilometer)			
	1981	2001	2012	2024
Sri Lanka	230	300	325	350
Colombo	2,605	3,330	3,438	3,551
Gampaha	994	1,539	1719	1776
Kalutara	516	677	775	805
Kandy	554	667	717	780
Galle	487	613	658	695
Matara	516	600	641	648
Jaffna	401	-	629	631
Kegalle	412	466	499	530
Nuwara Eliya	354	412	417	427
Kurunegala	254	316	350	380
Ratnapura	246	314	336	356
Badulla	227	276	288	314
Puttalam	165	246	265	278
Hambantota	164	211	240	273
Matale	180	226	248	268
Batticaloa	134	-	202	251
Trincomalee	98	-	150	181
Ampara	86	140	154	179
Anuradhapura	82	112	129	147
Polonnaruwa	77	117	132	137
Kilinochchi	-	-	94	115
Moneragala	49	72	82	96
Vavuniya	36	-	92	96
Mannar	53	-	53	66
Mullaitivu	39	-	38	51

Note :

- At the time of the 1981 Census, the Jaffna and Kilinochchi Districts functioned as a single district under the name Jaffna.
- In the 2001 Census, enumeration was not fully completed in the districts of Jaffna, Mannar, Vavuniya, Mullaitivu, Kilinochchi, Batticaloa, and Trincomalee. Therefore, after estimating the population for these districts, the population density for Sri Lanka was calculated based on the estimated total population of the country.
- In calculating the population density for 2024, the total land area of the country (67,240 km²), revised in August 2024 and published on the website by the Survey Department, along with the corresponding district land areas prepared accordingly, were used.

In the 1981 Census, the population density of Sri Lanka was 230 persons per square kilometer. By the 2024 Census, this had increased to 350 persons per square kilometer. Compared with 2012, the population density has increased by 25 persons per square kilometer, rising from 325 to 350 persons per square kilometer.

At the district level, the highest population density is reported from the Colombo District. Its population density, which was 2,605, 3,330, and 3,438 persons per square kilometer in the 1981, 2001, and 2012 censuses respectively, has further increased to 3,551 persons per square kilometer in 2024. Following Colombo, the next highest population density is reported from the adjacent Gampaha District, with 1,776 persons per square kilometer.